his afternoons to ‘philosophical studies… Astronomy, geography, and anatomy are his favourite pursuits, and he reads with avidity the works of Gassendi and Descartes’.

In his letter, Bernier criticizes Europeans who complain that the buildings in the Indies ‘are inferior in beauty to those of the Western world, forgetting that different climates require different styles of architecture; that what is useful and proper at Paris, London, or Amsterdam, would be entirely out of place at Delhi’. ‘In these hot countries,’ he explains, a beautiful house is capacious, ‘airy and exposed on all sides to the wind, especially to the northern breezes’. He adds, ‘A good house has its courtyards, gardens, trees, basins of water, small *jets d’eau* in the hall or at the entrance, and handsome subterraneous apartments which are furnished with large fans, and on account of their coolness are fit places for repose from noon until four or five o’clock, when the air becomes suffocatingly warm . . . no handsome dwelling is ever seen without terraces on which the family may sleep during the night.’ Bernier then describes the typical interiors of fine houses, their carpets, painted ceilings and flower pots. He describes the beauty of a few public buildings in Delhi, such as the Jama Masjid and the Caravanserai (demolished in the nineteenth century), as grand as the Palais Royale in Paris—‘the rendezvous of the rich Persian, Usbek, and other foreign merchants’.[2] ‘I think it may be safely asserted, without disparagement to the towns in our quarter of the globe, that the capital of Hindoustan is not destitute of handsome buildings, although they bear no resemblance to those in Europe.’ The Taj Mahal, he thinks, ‘deserves much more to be numbered among the wonders of the world than the pyramids of Egypt’.

Bernier estimates the population of Delhi as not ‘greatly less’ than that of Paris. ‘[Besides] the Omrahs [noblemen], the city never contains less than thirty-five thousand troopers, nearly all of whom have wives, children, and a great number of servants, who, as well as their masters, reside in separate houses,’ he notes. ‘The uniform and wide streets that so eminently distinguish Dehli [sic]’ from the old Mughal capital Agra, ‘are crowded with people . . . and, excepting a few carts, unincumbered with wheel carriages’. ‘Omrahs and Rajas ride thither, some on horseback, some on majestic elephants; but the greater part are conveyed on the shoulders of six